

LEAN & STRONG PLAYBOOK

6-DAY LIFTING

RUN 3-4x/WEEK

MILD DEFICIT

SIMPLE PROTEIN PLAN

186 lbs

Start Weight

~174 lbs

Target Range

~26%

Body Fat Now

150-160g

Daily Protein

Lean+Muscular

Goal

Built to get you lean and muscular — not skinny. Lose fat with a mild deficit while lifting hard to keep every pound of muscle.

THE STRATEGY — Read This First

Your goal: look good, get lean, stay muscular. You are fine losing weight but you do not want to end up a "stick." This plan is built exactly for that. Here is how it works and why.

WHY THIS APPROACH

- + MILD DEFICIT, NOT MAINTENANCE. You will eat ~400 cal below maintenance. This loses fat steadily (about 0.5-1 lb/week) so you actually see your physique change — fat is what hides your V-taper.
- + LIFTING IS WHAT KEEPS YOU FROM GETTING SKINNY. Heavy lifting 6 days a week signals your body to KEEP muscle while losing fat. Without it, a deficit eats muscle. With it, you stay strong and shapely.
- + PROTEIN PROTECTS MUSCLE. This is the single most important rule. High protein in a deficit = you lose fat, not muscle. Low protein = you get smaller everywhere. This is why the protein plan matters most.
- + YOU WILL NOT STAY SKINNY-SMALL. You drop from 186 to roughly 172-176 while lean, THEN you can slowly build muscle back up. The end result is a leaner, harder, more muscular you — not a thin you.
- + RUNNING IS A TOOL, NOT THE GOAL. 3-4 easy runs/week add fat-loss without eating into recovery. Daily running plus 6 lift days was too much — it would risk the exact skinny look you want to avoid.

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

DAY	LIFTING FOCUS	RUN	RUN DETAIL
Monday	Push A — Shoulder Focus	Yes	Easy 20-25 min, after lifting
Tuesday	Pull A — Width Focus	No	Rest from running
Wednesday	Legs A — Quad + HIIT	No	HIIT finisher covers cardio
Thursday	Push B — Chest Focus	Yes	Easy 20-25 min, after lifting
Friday	Pull B — Thickness Focus	Yes	Easy 20-25 min, after lifting
Saturday	Legs B — Posterior + HIIT	No	HIIT finisher covers cardio
Sunday	REST — Active Recovery	Opt.	Optional easy 20-30 min or walk

Running: 3 set days (Mon/Thu/Fri) + 1 optional (Sun). Easy pace — conversational. Always run AFTER lifting, never before.

PROTEIN GAME PLAN — The Most Important Page

You told me hitting protein is hard. This is the #1 thing to fix — without protein, no plan works and you risk losing muscle. The fix is to make it SIMPLE and lower the bar to a number you will actually hit.

NEW REALISTIC TARGET: 150-160g per day

A consistent 150g beats an aspirational 180g you never reach. Hit 150g daily and you are winning. If it gets easy, push toward 160-170g.

THE 4-BLOCK METHOD — ~40g protein, 4 times a day

BLOCK	EASIEST OPTIONS	PROTEIN
Block 1 — Morning	Protein shake (1-2 scoops) OR 4 eggs + Greek yogurt	40-50g
Block 2 — Midday	Canned tuna OR rotisserie/deli chicken OR turkey sandwich	35-45g
Block 3 — Post-Workout	Protein shake + milk — fast, drinkable, zero cooking	40-50g
Block 4 — Dinner	Any meat portion (chicken, beef, fish) palm-sized or bigger	35-45g

Two of four blocks are shakes — drinkable in seconds. That alone is ~90g with almost no effort.

NO-COOK / FAST PROTEIN SOURCES

FOOD	PROTEIN	WHY IT IS EASY
Whey protein shake (2 scoops)	~50g	Drinkable in seconds, cheapest protein per gram
Greek yogurt (non-fat, 1 cup)	~18-20g	Grab and eat, no prep
Cottage cheese (1 cup)	~25g	No prep, also great before bed
Canned tuna (1 can)	~25g	Zero cooking, very cheap, long shelf life
Rotisserie chicken	~25g/serving	Pre-cooked, just pull and eat
Deli turkey slices	~10g/2 oz	Grab and eat, sandwich or plain
Eggs (3 large)	~18g	Cheap, cooks in minutes
Milk (1 cup)	~8g	Easy calories, add to shakes
Beef jerky (1 oz)	~10-12g	Portable, keep some on you for emergencies

RULES THAT MAKE PROTEIN STICK

- + PROTEIN FIRST. Decide your protein source for each meal BEFORE anything else. Build carbs and fat around it.
- + KEEP SHAKES STOCKED. Running out of protein powder is the #1 reason people miss target. Always have a tub.
- + EAT PROTEIN FIRST ON THE PLATE. Physically eat the meat/eggs before the rice or sides — guarantees you get it in.
- + TRACK ONLY PROTEIN AT FIRST. Do not stress all macros yet. Just count protein grams daily until 150g is automatic.
- + PREP 2-3 DAYS OF MEAT AT ONCE. Cook a batch of chicken or ground beef so dinner protein is grab-and-go.
- + IF APPETITE IS LOW, DRINK IT. Liquid protein (shakes, milk) is easier than chewing when you are full.

GYM WORKOUTS — 6-DAY PROGRAM (24 Hour Fitness)

RPE: 7=moderate effort | 8=2 reps left | 9=1 rep left | 10=true max

DAY 1 **PUSH A — Shoulder-Dominant** **PUSH**

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Incline Barbell Press	4	6-10	RPE 8 — upper chest and shoulder tie-in
Seated DB Shoulder Press	4	8-10	RPE 8 — full range, no locking out
Cable Lateral Raises (unilateral)	4	15-20	RPE 9 — KEY V-taper exercise, strict form
Cable Triceps Pushdowns (rope)	3	12-15	RPE 9 — squeeze fully at bottom
Overhead Triceps Extension (cable)	3	10-12	RPE 9 — long head stretch

Tip: 4 sets of cable laterals is your only delt isolation today. Strict, no swinging.

DAY 2 **PULL A — Width-Dominant** **PULL**

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Weighted Pull-Ups (wide grip)	4	6-10	RPE 8 — #1 lat width builder, full stretch
Seated Cable Row (wide bar, FLARED)	3	10-12	RPE 8 — ELBOWS FLARED ~45 deg, upper back
Single-Arm DB Row (chest supported, TUCKED)	3	10-12	RPE 8 — ELBOWS TUCKED to ribs, hits lats
Rear Delt Fly (pec deck reverse)	3	15-20	RPE 9 — slow 3s eccentric, shoulder health
Incline DB Curl	3	10-12	RPE 9 — peak bicep stretch at bottom
Hammer Curls	3	12-15	RPE 9 — brachialis and forearm width

Tip: Pull-ups always go first. Flared row = upper back. Tucked row = lat thickness.

DAY 3 **LEGS A — Quad-Dominant + Core + HIIT** **LEGS**

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Back Squat	4	6-8	RPE 8 — controlled descent, drive through heels
Leg Press (feet high & wide)	3	12-15	RPE 9 — builds quad sweep
Leg Extension Machine	3	12-15	RPE 9 — full squeeze at top
Seated Hamstring Curl	3	10-12	RPE 9 — slow 3s eccentric, full contraction
Standing Calf Raises	4	15-20	RPE 9 — pause 1s at top
Hanging Leg Raises	3	15-20	RPE 9 — no swinging, controlled
HIIT Finisher (bike/treadmill)	—	10 min	20s max sprint / 40s rest x 10 rounds

GYM WORKOUTS — CONTINUED

DAY 4

PUSH B — Chest-Dominant

PUSH

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Barbell Bench Press (flat)	4	6-10	RPE 8 — retract scapula, controlled descent
Incline DB Press (30 degrees)	3	8-10	RPE 8 — targets upper chest
Cable Lateral Raises (bilateral)	4	15-20	RPE 9 — different stimulus than Day 1
Dips (weighted if possible)	3	8-12	RPE 9 — lean forward for chest emphasis
Triceps Overhead Ext. (EZ bar)	3	10-12	RPE 9 — full overhead stretch

Tip: Both push days hit side delts hard — that width is what builds the V-taper look.

DAY 5

PULL B — Thickness-Dominant

PULL

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Pull-Ups AMRAP (bodyweight)	4	AMRAP	RPE 9 — log reps each set, beat weekly
Barbell Row (TUCKED)	4	8-10	RPE 8 — ELBOWS TUCKED, heavy lat thickness
Flat Chest-Supported DB Row (FLARED)	3	10-12	RPE 8 — ELBOWS FLARED ~45 deg, upper back
Straight-Arm Lat Pulldown (cable)	3	12-15	RPE 9 — isolation, squeeze lats at bottom
Face Pulls (cable rope)	3	15-20	RPE 8 — external rotation, shoulder health
Preacher Curl or EZ Bar Curl	3	10-12	RPE 9 — strict form, no body swing
Reverse Curls	2	12-15	RPE 8 — forearm and brachialis

Tip: Tucked barbell row = lat thickness. Flared chest-supported row = upper back.

DAY 6

LEGS B — Posterior Chain + Core + HIIT

LEGS

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE / NOTES
Romanian Deadlift (RDL)	4	8-10	RPE 8 — hinge at hips, big hamstring stretch
Hip Thrust — Barbell	4	10-12	RPE 9 — squeeze glutes hard at top
Walking Lunges (DB)	3	10/leg	RPE 8 — long stride, knee tracks toe
Lying Hamstring Curl	3	10-12	RPE 9 — slow 3s down, full squeeze
Seated Calf Raises	4	15-20	RPE 9 — different angle vs Day 3
Ab Wheel Rollouts	3	10-12	RPE 9 — slow, core braced throughout
HIIT Finisher (bike/treadmill)	—	12 min	20s max sprint / 40s rest x 12 rounds

BACKUP PLAN — When You Cannot Make It To The Gym

Keep it simple. On days you cannot make the gym, do the AMRAP circuit below — As Many Reps As Possible of basic bodyweight movements. This is a MAINTENANCE day, not a progress day. Your real gains happen at the gym; this just keeps your body moving and burns calories.

THE CIRCUIT — 4 ROUNDS, REST 60-90 SEC BETWEEN ROUNDS

EXERCISE	REPS	TARGET MUSCLES	FORM CUE
Push-Ups	AMRAP	Chest, shoulders, triceps	Slow 2s down, full range
Bodyweight Squats	AMRAP	Quads, glutes, legs	Go to parallel or deeper
Sit-Ups or Crunches	AMRAP	Abs, core	Slow and controlled
Reverse Lunges (each leg)	15/leg	Quads, glutes, hamstrings	Step back, knee almost to floor
Plank Hold	45-60s	Core, shoulders	Straight line, no sagging
Jumping Jacks or Mountain Climbers	60 sec	Full body, cardio	Keep moving the whole time

HOW TO RUN IT

- + Do each exercise back-to-back with minimal rest between exercises.
- + After completing all 6 exercises, that is ONE ROUND. Rest 60-90 seconds.
- + Repeat for 4 total rounds. Whole thing takes ~25-30 minutes.
- + TRACK YOUR REPS. Write down how many push-ups, squats, sit-ups you got each round.
- + NEXT TIME, BEAT YOUR REPS. This is your version of progressive overload at home.
- + If you have time and energy, add a 15-20 min easy run or walk after.

HONEST EXPECTATIONS

Push-ups and squats hit chest, shoulders, triceps, and legs reasonably well. But bodyweight at home cannot replicate heavy back work — your lats, traps, and rear delts (the big V-taper muscles) will maintain rather than grow on this circuit alone. That is fine as a backup. The gym does the heavy lifting (literally). Just do not turn this into your main plan or your back development will stall.

RUNNING — 3 to 4 Times Per Week

Running is a fat-loss tool here, not the main event. 3-4 easy runs per week add calorie burn without eating into the recovery your muscles need. Daily running plus 6 lift days was too much — it would risk the skinny look you want to avoid. Keep runs EASY and they will help, not hurt.

HOW RUNNING AFFECTS YOU

EFFECT	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW THIS PLAN MANAGES IT
Faster fat loss	Extra calorie burn speeds up waist reduction	3-4 easy runs/week adds burn without overload
Better conditioning	Heart and lung fitness improve, lifts feel easier	Even 20 min easy runs build a solid aerobic base
Recovery cost	Too much running drains energy from lifting	Capped at 3-4 runs, easy pace, always after lifting
Muscle risk	Excess cardio in a deficit can burn muscle	Limited volume + 150g+ protein protects muscle

RUNNING RULES

- + EASY PACE ONLY. You should be able to hold a conversation. If you are gasping, slow down.
- + RUN AFTER LIFTING. Never before — lifting is the priority and you do not want pre-fatigued muscles.
- + NO RUNNING ON LEG DAYS. Your HIIT finisher already covers cardio on Wed and Sat.
- + BUILD UP SLOWLY. Week 1-2: start at 15 min. Week 3-4: 20 min. Week 5+: 20-25 min.
- + HARD CARDIO = HIIT ONLY. Your 2x weekly HIIT finishers are the intense work. Runs stay easy.
- + REPLACE SHOES every 300-400 miles to avoid shin splints and knee pain.

NUTRITION & MACROS — Mild Deficit For Fat Loss

Goal: lose fat steadily while keeping muscle. You eat in a mild deficit (~400 cal below maintenance), lifting hard so your body keeps muscle. Expect ~0.5-1 lb/week of fat loss. Protein is the rule that guarantees the weight you lose is fat, not muscle.

CALORIE TARGETS (mild deficit, includes 3-4 runs/week)

SCENARIO	DAILY CALORIES	WHEN TO USE
Fat loss (default)	1,900 - 2,050 cal	Most days — your standard target
Training + run day	2,050 - 2,200 cal	Days with both lifting and a run
Refeed day (once a week)	2,300 - 2,450 cal	One higher day keeps energy and sanity up
Stall buster	1,800 - 1,900 cal	Only if weight stalls 3+ weeks

If you lose weight too fast (more than 1.5 lb/week consistently), eat 150-200 cal more — fast loss means muscle loss.

DAILY MACRO TARGETS

MACRO	DAILY TARGET	NOTES
Protein	150-160g	NON-NEGOTIABLE. Protects muscle. See Protein Game Plan page
Carbs	150-180g	Fuel for lifts. Put most around your workout
Fat	55-65g	Hormones and health. Do not go too low
Fiber	28-32g	Keeps you full in a deficit — big help with hunger
Water	1 gallon+	Helps appetite control and performance

Track protein FIRST. Once 150g is automatic, start tracking carbs and fat too.

SAMPLE DAY (~2,000 cal, ~155g protein)

MEAL	EXAMPLE	PROTEIN
Breakfast	3 eggs + 1 cup Greek yogurt + banana	~38g
Lunch	Rotisserie chicken + rice + vegetables	~40g
Post-Workout	Protein shake (2 scoops) + cup of milk	~55g
Dinner	Lean beef or fish + sweet potato + greens	~38g

FOODS, SUPPLEMENTS & PROGRESS TRACKING

EAT OFTEN	LIMIT — OK OCCASIONALLY	CUT BACK / AVOID
Chicken breast and thighs Ground turkey and lean beef Eggs and egg whites Canned tuna and salmon Greek yogurt and cottage cheese Rice, oats, sweet potato Broccoli, spinach, peppers Avocado and olive oil Beans and lentils Fruit (berries, banana)	Whole wheat bread and pasta Low-fat cheese Natural peanut butter Clean protein bars White rice and potatoes Dark chocolate (70%+) Low-sodium deli meats	Soda and liquid calories Fast food and fried food Alcohol (slows fat loss most) Processed snacks and chips Sugary cereals and pastries Excess condiments Fruit juice (eat whole fruit)

SUPPLEMENTS & RECOMMENDED BRANDS

Look for the **NSF Certified for Sport** or **Informed Sport** seal — it means the product was third-party tested for purity and banned substances.

SUPPLEMENT	DOSE / TIMING	TRUSTED BRANDS	PURPOSE
Whey Protein (priority)	1-2 scoops, daily	Optimum Nutrition Gold Standard, Transparent Labs, Legion, Klean Athlete	Your easiest path to 150g protein
Creatine (priority)	5g daily, any time	Any Creapure-based brand, NOW Sports, BulkSupplements, Thorne	Strength and muscle retention in a deficit
Vitamin D3 + K2	2,000-5,000 IU, w/ meal	Thorne, NOW Foods, Nordic Naturals	Recovery, immunity, hormones
Omega-3 Fish Oil	2-3g EPA/DHA, w/ food	Nordic Naturals, Thorne, Legion Triton	Joints, inflammation, fat metabolism
Magnesium Glycinate	300-400mg, before bed	Thorne, NOW Foods, Pure Encapsulations	Sleep quality and recovery
Electrolytes	Per packet, on run days	LMNT, Liquid I.V., NOW Sports	Hydration and performance

Whey and creatine are the only two that matter much. Whey is your protein lifeline — never run out. Creatine: any "Creapure" product is safe regardless of the label.

PROGRESS TRACKING CHECKLIST

- + Hit 150g protein daily — this is the one rule you cannot skip. Track it before anything else.
- + Weigh in monthly on the 18th — look at the trend. Aim for ~0.5-1 lb loss per week on average.
- + Measure your waist monthly — this is the real "looking good" marker. Target: under 33 inches.
- + Log every workout (Strong app, free) — keep your weights climbing so you keep muscle while leaning out.
- + Take a monthly front photo, same lighting and pose — the mirror shows what the scale cannot.
- + Sleep 7-9 hours — poor sleep wrecks recovery and makes you hungrier.
- + If you feel weak or flat for 2+ weeks, eat a bit more — losing fat slower beats losing muscle.

THE FORMULA

150g+ protein daily • Lift 6 days, push the weights up • Run easy 3-4x • Mild deficit • Sleep 8 hours

Lifting heavy + high protein is what makes you lose FAT and not muscle. That is how you get lean and strong instead of skinny. Trust it for 90 days.